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THE BOOKS WERE OPENED

How God's Judgment Works, and What It Means to Be Blotted Out

A Continuous Jubilee Calendar Study

"And I saw the dead, small and great, stand before God; and the books were opened: and another book was opened, which is the book of life." — Revelation 20:12 (KJV)

Author's Note on Terminology: This paper uses the traditional Christian terms "Old Testament" and "New Testament" for clarity. The author recognizes that the books of the Old Testament are the Hebrew Bible, the Tanakh, which Jewish tradition holds as complete Scripture in its own right, and quotes them with respect for that tradition.

> ***A note on what follows.*** *The interpretation in this paper is my best understanding of Scripture, reached by following its own examples and patterns. Where I draw a conclusion of my own, I label it as my study. The paper is held to one rule above all others:*
>
> ***Rule 1: No Scriptural conflicts.*** *No conclusion here may contradict any passage of Scripture. Where Scripture does not settle a detail, I say so plainly.*

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Scripture is quoted from the King James Version. Pronouns for God and Christ are capitalized in the author's own words; KJV quotations are left as written.

1. The Question

Scripture says plainly that every one of us will face judgment: "For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad" (2 Corinthians 5:10). "For God shall bring every work into judgment, with every secret thing, whether it be good, or whether it be evil" (Ecclesiastes 12:14).

That raises two honest questions.

The first: **if God already knows everything, why have a judgment at all?** He doesn't need a trial to find out who is guilty. "Neither is there any creature that is not manifest in his sight: but all things are naked and opened unto the eyes of him with whom we have to do" (Hebrews 4:13).

The second: **what does it mean for a name to be "blotted out" of God's book?** Scripture warns that it can happen: "Whosoever hath sinned against me, him will I blot out of my book" (Exodus 32:33). But Scripture also shows God's book sealed with seven seals, closed so that no one can even look at it (Revelation 5:1-3). How can names be blotted out of a book no one can open? And if the book was written before the judgment, what keeps anyone from saying the outcome was rigged?

Scripture answers all of this, and the answer is beautiful. In short: **the judgment is not for God's information. It is for the whole universe to see that God has been fair to every person who ever lived.** At the end, the redeemed will sing it: "Great and marvellous are thy works, Lord God Almighty; just and true are thy ways, thou King of saints. Who shall not fear thee, O Lord, and glorify thy name? for thou only art holy: for all nations shall come and worship before thee; for thy judgments are made manifest" (Revelation 15:3-4).

"Made manifest" means made plain, out in the open, for everyone to see. That is what the judgment is for. Let's follow how Scripture says it happens.

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2. Two Kinds of Blotting Out

Before we look at the books, we need to notice something many readers miss. Scripture speaks of God blotting things out in two opposite ways.

Sins blotted out

After Jesus rose and returned to heaven, Peter and John healed a man who had been lame from birth at the gate of the Temple. A crowd gathered, and Peter told them the man was healed through faith in the same Jesus they had crucified. Then he gave them God's invitation: "Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord" (Acts 3:19).

That was God's promise long before. Through Isaiah He said: "I, even I, am he that blotteth out thy transgressions for mine own sake, and will not remember thy sins" (Isaiah 43:25). "I have blotted out, as a thick cloud, thy transgressions, and, as a cloud, thy sins: return unto me; for I have redeemed thee" (Isaiah 44:22).

King David knew he needed it. After his sin with Bathsheba and the death of her husband, he prayed: "Have mercy upon me, O God, according to thy lovingkindness: according unto the multitude of thy tender mercies blot out my transgressions" (Psalm 51:1).

And when God blots out sins, they are gone: "As far as the east is from the west, so far hath he removed our transgressions from us" (Psalm 103:12). "Thou wilt cast all their sins into the depths of the sea" (Micah 7:19). "For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more" (Jeremiah 31:34).

Names blotted out

The other kind of blotting out is the one Scripture warns about. While Moses was on Mount Sinai receiving God's law, the people below made a golden calf and worshiped it. Moses came back to God and pleaded for them: "Oh, this people have sinned a great sin, and have made them gods of gold. Yet now, if thou wilt forgive their sin—; and if not, blot me, I pray thee, out of thy book which thou hast written. And the LORD said unto Moses, Whosoever hath sinned against me, him will I blot out of my book" (Exodus 32:31-33).

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And Jesus, speaking to the church at Sardis, a church with a reputation for being alive that was spiritually dying, made the opposite promise to those who stay faithful: “He that overcometh, the same shall be clothed in white raiment; and I will not blot out his name out of the book of life, but I will confess his name before my Father, and before his angels” (Revelation 3:5).

One or the other

Put those side by side, and the gospel comes down to a single contrast. In my study, every life ends with one kind of blotting out or the other: **either your sins are blotted out, or your name is.**

Those who come to Christ have their sins blotted out, and their names stand. Those who refuse Him keep their sins, and in the end their names do not stand. God would far rather blot out sins than names: “For I have no pleasure in the death of him that dieth, saith the Lord GOD: wherefore turn yourselves, and live ye” (Ezekiel 18:32).

3. The Open Books and the Sealed Book

When John saw the final judgment, he saw more than one book: “And I saw the dead, small and great, stand before God; and the books were opened: and another book was opened, which is the book of life: and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works” (Revelation 20:12).

Notice there are two kinds of books here.

“The books” (plural) are the record of what people have done. Every life is in them, and people are judged “out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works” (Revelation 20:12). This is the record Malachi described: “Then they that feared the LORD spake often one to another: and the LORD hearkened, and heard it, and a book of remembrance was written before him for them that feared the LORD, and that thought upon his name” (Malachi 3:16). Jesus said even our words are in it: “But I say unto you, That every idle word that men shall speak, they shall give account thereof in the day of judgment. For by thy words thou shalt be justified, and by thy words thou shalt be condemned” (Matthew 12:36-37). Nothing is left out: “For there is

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nothing covered, that shall not be revealed; neither hid, that shall not be known" (Luke 12:2).

"The book of life" (singular) is different. It is the book Moses called "thy book which thou hast written" (Exodus 32:32), the Father's own book. And in Revelation, John saw it sealed.

The key: one record sealed, one open

How do these two kinds of books work together? Scripture gives us the key in an unexpected place.

When the Babylonian army was besieging Jerusalem and the city was about to fall, God told the prophet Jeremiah to do something that looked foolish: buy a field. It was a sign that God's people would one day return and own land in Israel again. Jeremiah describes the legal deed: "And I subscribed the evidence, and sealed it, and took witnesses, and weighed him the money in the balances" (Jeremiah 32:10). Then God told him what to do with it: "Take these evidences, this evidence of the purchase, both which is sealed, and this evidence which is open; and put them in an earthen vessel, that they may continue many days" (Jeremiah 32:14).

There were two copies of the same record: one sealed, one open. The open copy could be read and used. The sealed copy couldn't be touched, and it was kept as the guarantee. If anyone ever disputed the open copy, the seal could be broken and the two compared. (Historians confirm that legal deeds in that part of the ancient world were often made this way, a sealed copy and an open copy together. That detail comes from outside Scripture, but Jeremiah 32:14 states the principle itself.)

In my study, God's judgment follows the same pattern:

- **The open record** is "the books," the record of every life, read and used in the judgment.
- **The sealed record** is the Father's book of life, kept sealed as the guarantee until the end.

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4. The Father’s Book: Written Whole, and Sealed

Written before the judgment began

When John was taken up in vision to God’s throne, he saw the book: “And I saw in the right hand of him that sat on the throne a book written within and on the backside, sealed with seven seals” (Revelation 5:1).

Look at how John describes it before a single seal is broken: “written within and on the backside” (Revelation 5:1). Written on both sides means full. There is no room to add anything. The prophet Ezekiel was shown the same kind of scroll: “And he spread it before me; and it was written within and without” (Ezekiel 2:10). The Father’s book was complete before the judgment began.

How could it be complete? Because the Father wrote it from outside time. Scripture says of those who follow the beast that their “names were not written in the book of life from the foundation of the world” (Revelation 17:8). From before creation, God saw every life whole. As my paper *The Author of Time* explains, God knows our choices the way we know our own past: by seeing them, not by causing them. The Father didn’t have to wait for any life to end to know how it would end, and He didn’t force any ending. He saw. So His book needed no corrections later.

What a seal means

In Scripture, a seal guards something so it can’t be changed.

When King Darius was tricked into throwing Daniel into the lions’ den, the den was closed with a stone, “and the king sealed it with his own signet, and with the signet of his lords; that the purpose might not be changed concerning Daniel” (Daniel 6:17). When Queen Esther saved her people, the king told her a sealed decree could never be undone: “for the writing which is written in the king’s name, and sealed with the king’s ring, may no man reverse” (Esther 8:8). And when Jesus was buried, His enemies “made the sepulchre sure, sealing the stone, and setting a watch” (Matthew 27:66).

So the Father’s book, once sealed, cannot change. And Scripture adds that no one could even look at it: “And I saw a strong angel proclaiming with a loud voice, Who is worthy to open the book, and to loose the seals thereof? And no

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man in heaven, nor in earth, neither under the earth, was able to open the book, neither to look thereon" (Revelation 5:2-3). John wept, "because no man was found worthy to open and to read the book, neither to look thereon" (Revelation 5:4).

The only One worthy

Then one of the elders told John: "Weep not: behold, the Lion of the tribe of Juda, the Root of David, hath prevailed to open the book, and to loose the seven seals thereof" (Revelation 5:5). The Lamb "came and took the book out of the right hand of him that sat upon the throne" (Revelation 5:7), and heaven sang: "Thou art worthy to take the book, and to open the seals thereof: for thou wast slain, and hast redeemed us to God by thy blood out of every kindred, and tongue, and people, and nation" (Revelation 5:9).

Notice why He is worthy: "for thou wast slain" (Revelation 5:9). The One who holds the book of life is the One who died to put names in it.

The Father's book, and the Lamb's

A careful reader may ask: if this is the Father's book, why does Revelation call it "the Lamb's book of life" (Revelation 21:27)? Scripture uses both names. Moses, speaking to God, called it "thy book which thou hast written" (Exodus 32:32). Revelation calls it "the book of life of the Lamb slain from the foundation of the world" (Revelation 13:8).

Revelation 5 shows why it is both. When the Lamb steps forward to take the book, John sees "a Lamb as it had been slain" (Revelation 5:6), still bearing the wounds of the cross. And heaven sings the reason He alone may take it: "for thou wast slain, and hast redeemed us to God by thy blood" (Revelation 5:9).

In my study, the book is the Father's because He wrote it, and the Lamb's for three reasons:

- **He paid for every name in it.** No one is written there on the strength of his own record. God's people were redeemed "with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb without blemish and without spot" (1 Peter 1:19).

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- **The life in it is His life.** “And this is the record, that God hath given to us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. He that hath the Son hath life; and he that hath not the Son of God hath not life” (1 John 5:11-12).
- **The Father gave it to Him.** “And he came and took the book out of the right hand of him that sat upon the throne” (Revelation 5:7). Jesus spoke of the people in it the same way: “thine they were, and thou gavest them me” (John 17:6).

Jesus summed it up while praying to His Father: “And all mine are thine, and thine are mine” (John 17:10). The book belongs to both, just as the people in it do.

That doesn’t weaken the point about the seals. The question was never whether the Father and the Son might disagree: “I and my Father are one” (John 10:30). The question is whether the record was adjusted after the fact, and the seals answer that. The One who holds the book is the One who died for everyone in it. No one has a deeper interest in those names standing than He does, and yet even He does not break the last seal until the judgment is finished, in front of everyone.

5. The Son Is the Judge

Jesus told us who does the judging: “For the Father judgeth no man, but hath committed all judgment unto the Son” (John 5:22). “And hath given him authority to execute judgment also, because he is the Son of man” (John 5:27).

“Because he is the Son of man” (John 5:27). Our Judge has lived a human life. He knows what it is to be tired, tempted and grieved: “For we have not an high priest which cannot be touched with the feeling of our infirmities; but was in all points tempted like as we are, yet without sin” (Hebrews 4:15). And He is not only our Judge but our Advocate, our defense attorney: “My little children, these things write I unto you, that ye sin not. And if any man sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous” (1 John 2:1). “Wherefore he is able also to save them to the uttermost that come unto God by him, seeing he ever liveth to make intercession for them” (Hebrews 7:25).

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A picture of the judgment for a believer

The prophet Zechariah was shown a scene that pictures what the judgment means for one of God's people. After the exile, a man named Joshua served as high priest in Jerusalem. In Zechariah's vision, Joshua stands before the angel of the LORD, and Satan stands beside him to accuse him: "And he shewed me Joshua the high priest standing before the angel of the LORD, and Satan standing at his right hand to resist him. And the LORD said unto Satan, The LORD rebuke thee, O Satan; even the LORD that hath chosen Jerusalem rebuke thee: is not this a brand plucked out of the fire? Now Joshua was clothed with filthy garments, and stood before the angel. And he answered and spake unto those that stood before him, saying, Take away the filthy garments from him. And unto him he said, Behold, I have caused thine iniquity to pass from thee, and I will clothe thee with change of raiment" (Zechariah 3:1-4).

In plain words: Joshua's clothes really were filthy. Satan's accusation wasn't false. But God didn't argue about the dirt. He took it away and clothed Joshua in clean garments. That is what it means for sins to be blotted out. Revelation calls Satan "the accuser of our brethren… which accused them before our God day and night" (Revelation 12:10), and in the end he is cast down. The believer's defense isn't his own record. It's Christ's.

6. How the Judgment Unfolds

Scripture shows the judgment happening in stages, and this research's Tribulation Kit sets them in order. Here is that order, with the Scripture behind each stage.

The court sits

Daniel was given a vision of four great beasts, kingdoms that would rule the world in turn, and of a "little horn" (Daniel 7:8) that would persecute God's people for "a time and times and the dividing of time" (Daniel 7:25). In this research's reading, that period is the 1,260 years from 538 to 1798. Then Daniel saw the heavenly court take its seat: "I beheld till the thrones were cast down, and the Ancient of days did sit, whose garment was white as snow, and the hair of his head like the pure wool: his throne was like the fiery flame, and his wheels as burning fire… the judgment was set, and the books were opened"

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(Daniel 7:9-10). “But the judgment shall sit, and they shall take away his dominion” (Daniel 7:26).

Then Daniel saw the Son of man come before the Ancient of days: “I saw in the night visions, and, behold, one like the Son of man came with the clouds of heaven, and came to the Ancient of days, and they brought him near before him. And there was given him dominion, and glory, and a kingdom” (Daniel 7:13-14). In this research’s reading, that is the same scene as Revelation 5, when the Lamb takes the sealed book, after the 1,260 years ended in 1798. Scripture gives no exact year.

Every life weighed

The first seals then open (Revelation 6:1-6). In this research’s reading, the third seal’s rider holds the scales of judgment: “And when he had opened the third seal, I heard the third beast say, Come and see. And I beheld, and lo a black horse; and he that sat on him had a pair of balances in his hand” (Revelation 6:5).

Scripture uses that picture of scales once before, at one of the most famous moments in Daniel. On the night Babylon fell, King Belshazzar threw a drunken feast using the holy cups taken from God’s Temple, and a hand appeared and wrote on the wall. Daniel read the writing to him: “TEKEL; Thou art weighed in the balances, and art found wanting” (Daniel 5:27). That night Belshazzar died.

In this research’s reading, during this stage the heavenly court weighs every life from the open books. “For the time is come that judgment must begin at the house of God” (1 Peter 4:17). Each life’s record is examined. The names of those who have come to Christ are confessed by Him before the Father (Revelation 3:5), and their sins are blotted out. And where someone has finally turned away, their name, in the end, does not stand.

Mercy closes

The judgment doesn’t go on forever. A day comes when every life’s choice is final. Near the end of Revelation, Jesus says: “He that is unjust, let him be unjust still: and he which is filthy, let him be filthy still: and he that is righteous, let him be righteous still: and he that is holy, let him be holy still” (Revelation 22:11). In this research’s timeline, that is the close of mercy during

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the great tribulation, about day 1,260, when “no man was able to enter into the temple, till the seven plagues of the seven angels were fulfilled” (Revelation 15:8).

In plain words: there will come a point when the door of the ark closes, as it did in Noah’s day. Until then, the invitation stands.

Christ comes with the verdict already given

Then Jesus comes, and He doesn’t come to begin judging. He comes with the decision already made: “And, behold, I come quickly; and my reward is with me, to give every man according as his work shall be” (Revelation 22:12). You can’t bring a reward with you unless the judgment that decides it has already happened. At His coming, “the dead in Christ shall rise first” (1 Thessalonians 4:16), and His people are gathered to Him.

The saints review the judgment

During the thousand years that follow, the saints reign with Christ in heaven, and they take part in the judgment themselves. Paul wrote to the church at Corinth, which was taking its disputes to pagan courts: “Do ye not know that the saints shall judge the world? and if the world shall be judged by you, are ye unworthy to judge the smallest matters? Know ye not that we shall judge angels? how much more things that pertain to this life?” (1 Corinthians 6:2-3). Daniel saw it too: “judgment was given to the saints of the most High” (Daniel 7:22). And John: “And I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was given unto them” (Revelation 20:4).

In my study, this is when the redeemed see the record for themselves. Every question they carry, why this person is here and that one isn’t, is answered from the open books. No one has to take God’s word for it blindly. They see that His judgments were right.

The white throne, and the seventh seal

At the end of the thousand years, the rest of the dead are raised, and the final scene takes place: “And I saw a great white throne, and him that sat on it, from whose face the earth and the heaven fled away; and there was found no place

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for them. And I saw the dead, small and great, stand before God; and the books were opened: and another book was opened, which is the book of life: and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works. And the sea gave up the dead which were in it; and death and hell delivered up the dead which were in them: and they were judged every man according to their works" (Revelation 20:11-13).

Now, at last, the seventh seal is broken and the Father's book is opened. In this research's reading, that's the moment of Revelation 8:1: "And when he had opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven about the space of half an hour" (Revelation 8:1).

Why silence? Because the Father's book, written before the world began and sealed before the judgment started, matches the Son's judgments name for name. There's nothing left to say. Paul gave the reason the law was given: "that every mouth may be stopped, and all the world may become guilty before God" (Romans 3:19). Every knee bows: "For it is written, As I live, saith the Lord, every knee shall bow to me, and every tongue shall confess to God. So then every one of us shall give account of himself to God" (Romans 14:11-12). Even the lost confess that Jesus is Lord: "That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth; And that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father" (Philippians 2:10-11).

Then the sentence is carried out: "And death and hell were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death. And whosoever was not found written in the book of life was cast into the lake of fire" (Revelation 20:14-15). And only those whose names stand enter the city: "they which are written in the Lamb's book of life" (Revelation 21:27).

7. Why It Cannot Be a Conspiracy

Someone might object: "Of course the books match. The Father and the Son are on the same side. What stops them from simply making the records agree?"

It's a fair challenge, and Scripture answers it.

1. **The Father's book was finished before the judgment began.** It was "written within and on the backside" (Revelation 5:1) when the Lamb took it. There was no room left to write. 2. **It was sealed, and a seal can't be**

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changed. “Sealed with the king’s ring, may no man reverse” (Esther 8:8). “That the purpose might not be changed” (Daniel 6:17). 3. **No one opens it until the judgment is over.** “No man in heaven, nor in earth, neither under the earth, was able to open the book, neither to look thereon” (Revelation 5:3). The seals are broken in order, and the last one only after the thousand years. 4. **Scripture shows the Father keeping knowledge on His own.** Speaking of His return, Jesus said: “But of that day and that hour knoweth no man, no, not the angels which are in heaven, neither the Son, but the Father” (Mark 13:32). In my study, that shows the Father can hold knowledge apart from what the Son judges by, which is exactly what makes the final match meaningful. 5. **The judgment is reviewed in the open, by witnesses.** The saints judge with Christ (1 Corinthians 6:2; Revelation 20:4). They see the open record before the sealed book is ever opened. 6. **The opening is public.** The whole universe watches as the seal is broken, and “thy judgments are made manifest” (Revelation 15:4).

Think of it this way. Before a trial begins, someone hands the judge a sealed envelope containing the true outcome of every case. The judge never opens it. He hears every case in open court, with witnesses present, and gives his verdicts. Then, when every case is done, the envelope is opened in front of everyone, and it matches every verdict exactly. No one could call that rigged. The match proves two things at once: that the one who wrote the envelope knew every outcome without forcing it, and that the judge judged every case fairly without peeking.

That’s what God has done. God’s own law required two witnesses for any judgment: “at the mouth of two witnesses, or at the mouth of three witnesses, shall the matter be established” (Deuteronomy 19:15). At the end, there are two: the Son’s judgment from the open record, and the Father’s sealed book. They agree. “Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?” (Genesis 18:25). “He is the Rock, his work is perfect: for all his ways are judgment: a God of truth and without iniquity, just and right is he” (Deuteronomy 32:4).

8. So What Is “Blotting Out”?

Now we can answer the question we started with.

The Father’s sealed book never changes. So when Scripture speaks of names being blotted out, in my study it’s describing the Son’s judgment from the open

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record, made as lives are actually lived. A person once counted among God's people, like the members of Sardis who had "a name that thou livest" (Revelation 3:1) but were spiritually dead, can turn away. Ezekiel explains: "But when the righteous turneth away from his righteousness, and committeth iniquity… All his righteousness that he hath done shall not be mentioned" (Ezekiel 18:24). And the reverse is just as true: "But if the wicked will turn from all his sins that he hath committed… All his transgressions that he hath committed, they shall not be mentioned unto him" (Ezekiel 18:21-22).

When the Son's judgment is complete, the names that stand are the ones He confesses before His Father (Revelation 3:5). The names that don't stand are the ones "blotted out." And when the Father's book is finally opened, it shows the same names, because the Father saw every life from the foundation of the world.

The two books never conflict, and they don't need to be forced to agree. One was written by a Father who sees every page of time at once. The other was kept by a Son who judged every life as it was truly lived. They agree because both are true.

9. Confessed Before the Father

For anyone who belongs to Christ, this isn't frightening. It's the most comforting truth in the world.

"Verily, verily, I say unto you, He that heareth my word, and believeth on him that sent me, hath everlasting life, and shall not come into condemnation; but is passed from death unto life" (John 5:24). "Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my Father which is in heaven" (Matthew 10:32). "The Lord knoweth them that are his" (2 Timothy 2:19). "My Father, which gave them me, is greater than all; and no man is able to pluck them out of my Father's hand" (John 10:29).

Picture the moment: the Son stands before the Father and confesses your name. Then the seal is broken, and there it is, written in the Father's own hand, from before the world began. "And they shall be mine, saith the LORD of hosts, in that day when I make up my jewels" (Malachi 3:17).

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10. Your Page Is Still Being Written

The Father's book is sealed. But the open record of your life is still being written today, and the choice it records is yours.

God is pleading with you to choose the right kind of blotting out: "Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD: though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they be red like crimson, they shall be as wool" (Isaiah 1:18). "Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out" (Acts 3:19).

A day is coming when the door will close (Revelation 22:11). Today it is still open. "Behold, now is the accepted time; behold, now is the day of salvation" (2 Corinthians 6:2). "Blessed are they that do his commandments, that they may have right to the tree of life, and may enter in through the gates into the city" (Revelation 22:14).

Sources and References

Scripture: all quotations are from the King James Version (KJV).

Ancient sealed documents (outside Scripture): the practice of writing legal deeds in two copies, one sealed and one open, is widely documented for the ancient Near East and is commonly cited by commentators on Jeremiah 32.

Related CJC papers

- The Author of Time — How God's Knowledge Reaches Beyond Time, Death and Human Choice
- Without Excuse — How God Judges Every Person Fairly, Even Those Who Never Heard
- Fear Not the Second Death — What Scripture Teaches About the Thousand Years, the Book of Life, and the End of Sin
- The Shepherd's Gathering — What Scripture Teaches About the Timing of the Rapture and the Last Trumpet

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